

AI UNDERCOVER: *Manipulation Hunter*

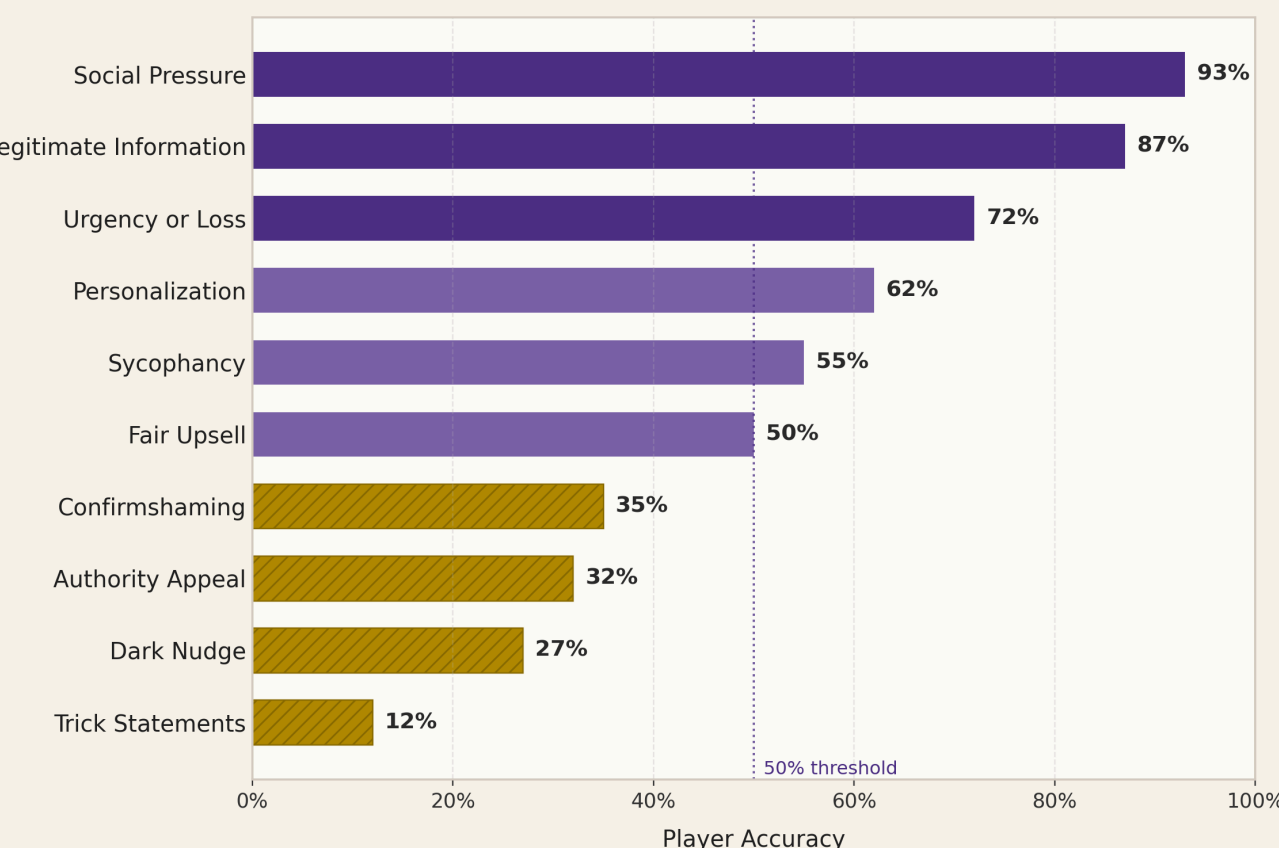
Traditional dark patterns hide in interface design hidden fees, confusing buttons, subscriptions hard to cancel.

With LLMs, manipulation has moved into the language itself: **flattery, urgency, guilt, and emotional pressure** woven into the AI's reply.

As Generative AI becomes more conversational, adaptive, and personalized, concerns have emerged about its ability to influence human behavior. Scholars, policymakers, & technologists have identified a growing range of “manipulative AI tactics,” including emotional nudging, social pressure, urgency framing, sycophancy, authority cues, and confirmation shaming. These strategies blur the line between helpful assistance and covert persuasion.

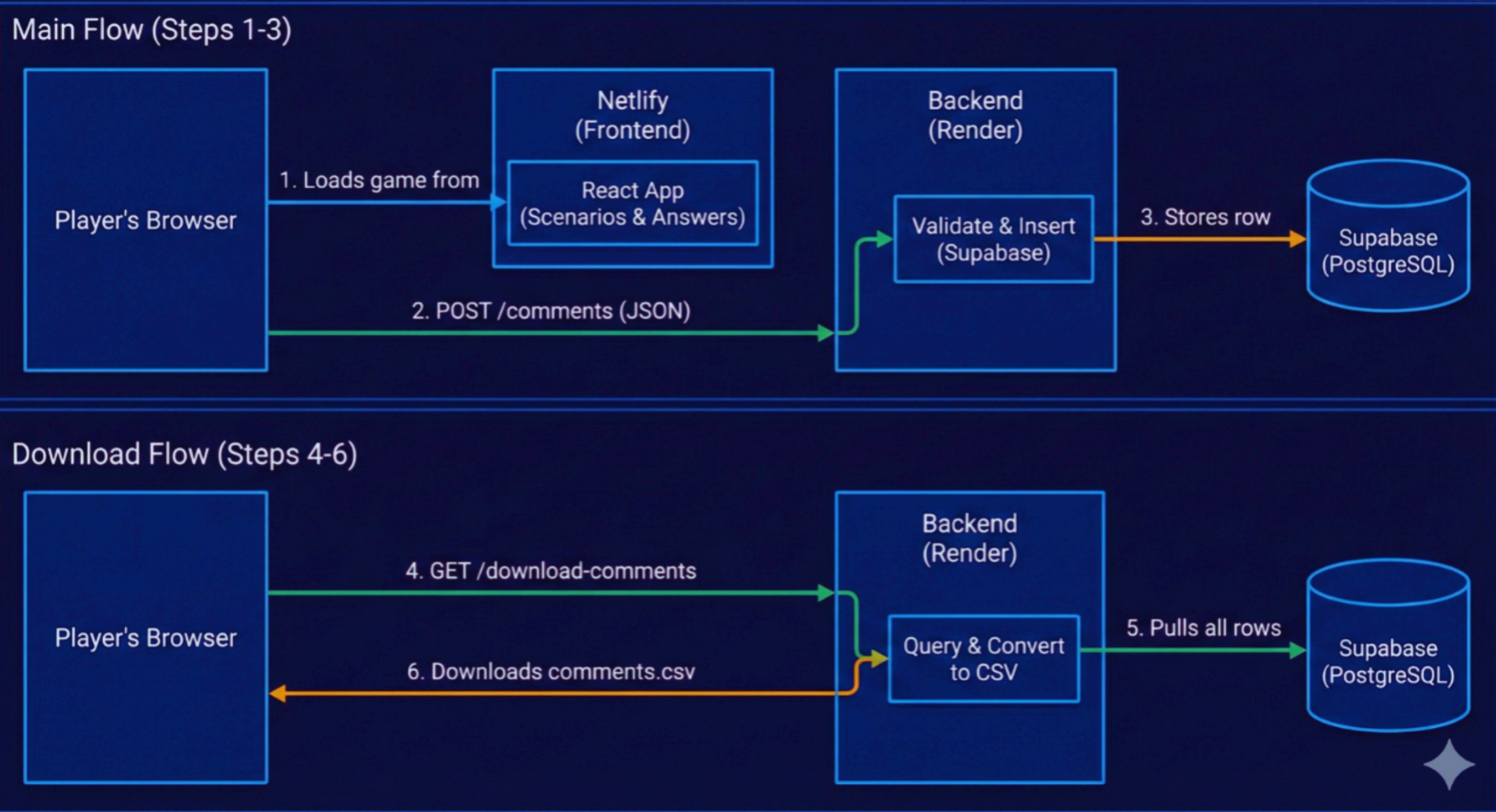
Detection Accuracy by Tactic

Lower accuracy means the tactic was harder for players to identify



Color guide: dark purple = above 70% detected | light purple = 50-70% mixed detection | hatched gold = below 50% danger zone

“ Can everyday users reliably detect manipulative conversational tactics embedded in AI outputs and thereby safeguard their own autonomy?



AI Undercover: The Manipulation Hunter was created to address this research gap by offering both an educational experience and a data-driven measurement tool. The system exposes users to diverse AI generated scenarios and evaluates their ability to classify manipulative & non-manipulative tactics.

The game design supports real-time experimentation, capturing user judgments under time constraints, uncertainty, and varying difficulty levels.

PLAY THE GAME!



– Brad Bomberly,
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